

Stack A — Game 1: Standard Attack Nerf

Version: 2026-05-19. Based on baseline rules v2026-05-19 + Layer 1 economy (accepted).

Feedback form (fill out after Game 2): [stack-a-feedback.pdf](#)

One change from baseline + Layer 1. Standard Attacks deal **1 DMG** instead of 2. Economy uses Layer 1 values (6 starting Runes, +2/turn scaling). All other rules unchanged.

Play this game FIRST, then play Game 2 (adds combo bonus).

Designer notes — read before facilitating, players can skip.

What we're testing: Does reducing Standard Attack damage from 2 to 1 make skills the primary damage source, create meaningful Injured states, and reduce the "wait and pounce" dynamic?

Hypothesis: Standard attacks at 2 DMG dominate the damage economy (free instant kills). At 1 DMG, a single attack only Injures — finishing a piece requires a second attack or a skill, making skills worth their Rune cost.

Watch for:

- Does the Injured state come up more often? Do Injured pieces survive multiple rounds?
- Is Guard clearing painfully slow? Track rounds to first Guard kill.
- Does the no-man's-land / standoff dissolve (lower risk to move forward)?
- Do players spend more Runes on Strike skills to finish pieces off?
- Does game length increase, decrease, or stay similar?

All rules below carry Layer 1 economy (accepted). The only new change is marked ⚡.

Goal

Capture the opponent's **King**. The game ends immediately when a King is removed from the board.

Draw conditions:

- No piece has been captured for 10 consecutive full rounds.
- Only the two Kings remain on the board.

Components

Per player: 1 King · 5 Champions · 6 Guards

Shared (Prototype): 10x10 grid board · Skill cards · Injured markers · Armor pieces

Skill Drafting

- Lay out all available skills face-up as a shared pool.
- Alternating draft: P1 picks 2 skills from the pool and assigns them freely to any of their Champions or King → P2 picks 2 skills and assigns freely → repeat.
- Continue until all 5 Champions and the King on each side have 2 skills.
- Both players draft from the same pool. Duplicates are allowed.

Setup

- **Board:** Use the 10x10 grid.
- **First player:** Flip a coin (or decide verbally).
- **Piece placement:** Each player places pieces on their own back two rows:
 - Back row (row 1/10): King in the centre, Champions fill the remaining 5 spaces.
 - Second row (row 2/9): All 6 Guards.
- **Skill Draft:** Alternating picks. P1 picks 2 skills from the pool and assigns them freely to any of their Champions or King, then P2. Repeat until all Champions and the King on each side have 2 skills each (12 per player). Duplicates allowed.
- **Starting Runes:** Each player starts with **6 Runes**.
- P1 begins Round 1.

Round Structure

A **Round** = P1's Turn + P2's Turn.

At the **start of each player's turn** (before they do anything), that player collects their Rune income. (*Exception: Round 1 — players begin with their starting Runes and collect nothing before their first turn.*)

Turn Structure

Each **Turn** has two phases, in order:

- **Movement Phase** — spend Move Slots to move pieces (and attack).
- **Action Phase** — spend Skill Slots to activate skills.

You may use 0 slots in either phase.

Movement Phase

You have **2 Move Slots** per turn. Spend 1 Move Slot to move one piece — either **into empty space** (normal movement) or **into an enemy tile** (a Standard Attack — see next section). **Each piece may only be moved once per Movement Phase.**

Piece	Normal speed	Injured speed
Guard	2 tiles	1 tile
Champion / King	1 tile	1 tile

Free pathing: A piece may move in any direction — horizontal, vertical, diagonal — taking any route up to its speed in tiles. The route does not have to be a straight line.

Pieces block movement: A moving piece cannot pass through any other piece, ally or opponent.

- *Exception:* A piece may go around a blocking piece if total tiles moved stays within speed (e.g. a Guard using 2 diagonal moves to go around a piece directly in the way).
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CHANGED: Standard Attack

	Baseline	This Layer
Standard Attack damage	2 DMG	1 DMG
Everything else	—	Unchanged

To attack, spend a Move Slot to move your piece **onto a tile occupied by an enemy piece.**

- Deal **1 DMG** to the enemy (*baseline: 2 DMG*).
- **If the enemy is removed:** your piece occupies the tile.
- **If the enemy survives:** your piece stops on the tile immediately before the target. (*If there are multiple paths toward the target you may choose which one to take — relevant for Bodyguard.*)

You may attack with one Move Slot and move a different piece with the other Move Slot in the same turn.

Action Phase

You have **2 Skill Slots** per turn (at the start (see Progression)).

Spend 1 Skill Slot to activate one equipped skill on one of your Champions or King:

- Announce the skill and the target.
- Pay the skill's Rune cost.
- Apply the skill's effect.

The same Champion can activate multiple skills (also the same one) in one turn if you have Skill Slots remaining.

Skill System

Skill Path: Skills travel in a **straight line** (horizontal, vertical, or diagonal) from the caster, like a chess Queen.

Blocking: The Skill Path is blocked by **all pieces** — ally and opponent alike. The skill cannot reach past the first piece in its path.

Range: The distance in tiles along the Skill Path from caster to target. Range is measured as:

- Range 0 = self (caster's own tile)
- Range 1 = adjacent tile along Skill Path
- Range 2 = 2 tiles away along Skill Path (etc.)

Default Range = 2. Unless a skill explicitly names “self” or “adjacent” in its effect text. A skill with a Range modifier (e.g. “Range –1”) is still a Range 2 skill with a modifier applied — it is not treated as adjacent or self.

Self vs. adjacent: “Self” skills (Range 0) target only the caster — they cannot target adjacent pieces, even with a Range buff. “Adjacent” skills (Range 1) target only neighbouring pieces — they cannot target the caster, even with a Range buff. Range buffs (e.g. Focus Strike) shift the targeting window outward; they do not collapse it inward.

Injured Range penalty: Injured pieces have Skill Range –1. Skills that explicitly name “self” or “adjacent” in their text are unaffected — they always work regardless of Injured status.

Skills that move pieces do not deal damage. Movement-via-skill (Quick Dash, Shadow Shift, Retreat Plan) does not count as a Standard Attack and deals no damage on arrival - you are instead stopped from moving the piece further in that direction.

A Champion may use its skills multiple times in the same turn if Skill Slots are available — including the same skill twice.

All skills cost 1 Skill Slot unless noted otherwise.

Resource Economy (Runes)

Starting Runes: 6 per player.

Rune income is collected at the **start of each player's own turn**:

Round	Income per player turn
1	0 (starting Runes only)
2-4	+2
5-9	+3
10-14	+4
15+	+5 (+1 every 5 rounds)

No Rune cap.

Progression

Round	Skill Slots per turn
1-10	2
11-20	3
21-30	4
31+	5 (+1 every 10 rounds)

Health & Armor

All pieces have 2 HP: Normal → Injured → Removed.

State	HP	Effect
Normal	2	No penalty
Injured	1	Speed capped at 1. Skill Range –1 (affects Range 2+ only).
Removed	0	Piece leaves the board permanently.

Damage:

- 1 DMG to Normal → Injured.
- 1 DMG to Injured → Removed.
- 2 DMG to Normal → Removed instantly (Injured state is skipped).

Armor: Max 3 points per piece. Each absorbs 1 DMG, then destroyed. Resolves before HP damage. **Does not prevent Injured status.**

Bodyguard Rule

When you make a **Standard Attack** against an opponent's Champion or King, the defender may choose to have a Guard intercept — **if** a friendly Guard is on a tile adjacent to **both the tile immediately before the target (along the attack path) and the defending piece.**

Interception:

- Defender announces a Guard to intercept.
- The Guard takes the damage instead of the original target.
- The attacker moves **1 tile** toward the target (stops on the tile immediately before the target).

Interception is optional. The defender may decline even if a Guard is eligible and can select which guard should take the damage if multiple Guards are eligible.

Only Standard Attacks can be intercepted. Skills always hit directly.

Skill Reference

	Cat.	Name	Cost	Effect
	Strike	Lance Thrust	2	Target within Range-1 takes 1 DMG
	Strike	Hook Pull	3	Target takes 1 DMG, pulled 1 tile toward caster along Skill Path
	Strike	Armor Breaker	2	Remove 1 Armor from target. <i>(Note: does not deal "HP-Damage" unless boosted by Blade Call)</i>
	Strike	Rune Theft	3	Target takes 1 DMG. Steal 1 Rune from opponent.
	Strike	Blade Tempest	4	Target takes 1 DMG. All pieces adjacent to the target are pushed 1 tile away from the target. The attacker/caster is not affected.
	Shield	Rust Shield	2	Self: gain +1 Armor
	Shield	Field Medic	3	Remove Injured from one adjacent ally
	Shield	Armorsmith	3	Adjacent ally gains +1 Armor
	Move	Quick Dash	3	Self: move up to 2 tiles along Skill Path
	Move	Air Blast	2	Push target enemy 1 tile directly away from caster
	Move	Precision Thrust	3	Push target enemy 1 tile in any direction (caster chooses). Range+1.
	Move	Shadow Shift	4	Swap position with an allied piece. Requires unobstructed Skill Path.
	Move	Retreat Plan	4	Self: move along Skill Path to land adjacent to one of your Guards. Range+1.
	Mystic	Focus Strike	1	The next skill used by any of your pieces this turn gains +1 Range. <i>(Note: can boost self and adjacent skills — Range 0 → 1, Range 1 → 2.)</i> Move skills: the caster chooses, when activating the Move skill, whether the +1 applies to its activation range (how far the skill can target) or its effect range (how far it moves/pushes). Not both.
	Mystic	Blade Call	3	One Strike skill used by any of your pieces this turn deals +1 DMG.

Quick Reference

Concept	Rule
Movement	Free pathing, $\leq$ speed in tiles, cannot pass through pieces. Each piece once per Movement Phase.
Guard speed	Normal: 2 tiles. Injured: 1 tile.
Champion / King speed	1 tile (Normal or Injured).
Standard Attack	Move onto enemy tile (1 Move Slot). 1 DMG (<i>baseline: 2</i>). Attacker stops before target if target survives.
Skill Path	Straight line (Queen-style). Blocked by all pieces — ally and enemy.
Skill Range	Default Range 2. Skills with “self” = Range 0. Skills with “adjacent” = Range 1. Range modifiers (e.g. Range-1) apply from default.
Injured Range penalty	Injured pieces: Skill Range -1. Does not affect “self” or “adjacent” skills.
Bodyguard	Standard Attacks on Champion/King only. Guard must be adjacent to both tile-before-target AND defender. Guard takes the hit. Defender chooses which eligible Guard intercepts.
Armor	Max 3 per piece. Each point absorbs 1 DMG before HP, then is destroyed. Does not prevent Injured status.
Health	2 HP: Normal → Injured → Removed. 1 DMG = one step. 2 DMG = skip Injured, Removed instantly.
Rune income	Collected at start of YOUR turn (not Round 1). Starts 6, then +2/+3/+4/+5 scaling.
Skill Slots	Start at 2/turn. Grow with Progression (Rounds 1–10: 2, 11–20: 3, 21–30: 4, 31+: 5).
Focus Strike	+1 Range to next skill this turn. Can boost self (→ adjacent) and adjacent (→ Range 2) skills. On Move skills, caster chooses: activation range OR effect range.
Blade Call	+1 DMG to one Strike skill this turn. Stacks with Combo Bonus.
Combo Bonus	Each enemy has a combo counter (resets end of your turn). Strike skill hits enemy → deal +counter DMG ; if hitter is a new Champion, counter +1. Standard Attacks excluded.